classic example of how we, still unsure of making satellite launching rockets, got it right, however, rudimentary the system may sound now.

It was one of those days in 1968 when we—Kalam, Sathya, Majeed and Sudhakar—huddled around our four-table workspace discussing the Judi-Dart rocket. We all wondered when we would make bigger rockets that can launch satellites. Without much scientific analysis, we would do this often. Sometimes we stayed back in the office, sleeping on our desks, sometimes on the beach, stargazing and dreaming aloud. Then Sudhakar had this brain wave. What if we can recover payloads or even rocket parts which fell into the Arabian Sea after our sounding rockets touched a maximum altitude of 70 km. There was nothing much to recover than a few short-life transponders or minor probes launched using hand-out rockets like Centaure from France and Nike Apache from the US, but the idea sounded interesting. The US was then progressing fast on recovery vehicles and probes. We got to the job immediately.

In a few weeks, Sudhakar developed a parachute deployment system to soft-land a decoy payload. I developed the ejection mechanism. But there was no rocket to integrate it with.

'The idea is to see if a hurtling payload would activate the parachute and soft-land on the sea,' said Sudhakar. 'So why do we integrate it into a rocket? Why not drop the stuff from a plane?'

Our enthusiasm was child-like—and infectious within the group. Looking at fishermen's children who flew kites on the Thumba beach, we reminded each other that we are not much different.

We called the Trivandrum Flying Club, which readily agreed to charter a two-seater Pushpak. So, here was the plan—the decoy probe will be integrated with Sudhakar's parachute system, which my ejection mechanism will deploy using a timer activated at the time of release from the aircraft. Pushpak, a flying machine of the 1950s vintage, can attain an altitude not more than 5,000 feet, but for the experiment, that would do. With the parachute deployed, the probe would float, glide and soft-land on the sea surface. On impact, it would release a dye that would turn an area